3. Defining the transition path from the current to the future state, and
4. Building political consensus or garnering public support for the change.

These elements are intertwined and are rarely sequential phases in the implementation process. Yet, they serve as a useful framework for project management.

The four parts require different skill sets. For example, we need visionaries and saints for the first element, who can rise above the morass of information, scientific knowledge and cacophony of self-interests. Preparation of the blueprint is science, engineering and public administration. A poorly designed transition path is often the main cause of policy failures, and thinking through a sound transition is more art than science. Consensus building is predominantly an art.

The opportunity in crisis

> *It's a mistake to believe that the change that has not yet come will never come. On 9/11 the world changed; on 10/26 the PATRIOT Act was passed. The Patriot Act was not written in 46 days. It was simply the instrument that was ready when the moment arrived.*
>
> 'Persuasive Language for Language Security: Making the case for software safety', conference talk by Mike Walker, 24 May 2018

The US politician, Rahm Emanuel, famously commented that 'a crisis is a terrible thing to waste'. Crises are important events where the 'Overton window' is enlarged, and there is a larger zone of possibility in stage 5 of the policy pipeline. Policymakers should be alert to these opportunities. More generally, there is a lot to be said for a policy process where a community chips away at stages 1 through 4 of the pipeline, and waits for the right moment when stage 5 will use the ideas and stages 6 and 7 will use the human capabilities.

The relationship between crises and reforms is, however, highly exaggerated. There are three contrary points of view that have to be kept in